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A Modern Morality Play

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE PASSING
OF MARS: A MODERN MORALITY PLAY ***

The Passing of Mars
A Modern Morality Play

By

MARGUERITE WILKINSON

Author of "In Vivid Gardens" and "By a Western Wayside"



Once, long ago, a peasant greatly desired to visit his king that he might obtain of him judgment and equity, and perhaps find favor. But he said within himself, "I am a faulty man; a homespun smock will scarce commend me to a king. I will stay at home and let others plead my case." And when his case was taken before the king, (who was a good and just man) the king said, "Why did he not come himself? Homespun I can forgive if a man bring his soul and stand before me bravely. I will have no dealings with go-betweens."

Here then, is my work, faulty, and plainly clad, but brave enough to go humbly before you who read and think, and by your thinking rule. If it find favor, it can be clothed anew in finer raiment. If judgment and equity prevail against it, surely it is well enough shrouded.

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To the memory of
my father,
a strong and valiant lover of the soul of man, and
to his brave mate
my mother

PERSONS OF THE PLAY

MARS, the ancient god of war.

SOUL OF MAN, his immortal enemy.

CAPITAL, }
LABOR, } in cartoon costumes.

RELIGION, two personalities.

CULT, the bastard brother of RELIGION, a fantastic *poseur*.

FLIP, a modern, the sophisticated intellect of large cities.

SCIENCE, a strong youth in laboratory costume.

POETRY, a serene old bard with a lyre.

MUSIC, a fair woman.

GLAMOUR, her seducer, wearing tinsel.

TRADE, a harlot.

THE OLD MOTHER, a plain sibyl of the people.

Men, women and children of the fighting nations of Europe in national
peasant costumes.



THE SCENE

The World Field, at harvest time and set of sun. On the right is The World Inn, and, in front of it, on the ground, a prostrate figure, clad in black and bound, SOUL OF MAN. On the left, near the front, are trees and flowers, piles of fruit and vegetables, a wagon load of grain, and, in the foreground, a tangle of vines, in which lies MARS, fast asleep. On the steps of The World Inn sits THE OLD MOTHER watching the women of all nations who are sitting sewing, chatting and tending babies in the center. At the back a road winds across from left to right and young girls are walking up and down with arms around each other's shoulders, singing and laughing. The melody ("The Happy Farmer") dies away gradually and a church bell is heard—The Angelus. There is a religious silence lasting for a moment or two.



A WOMAN

The Angelus!

ANOTHER

Already day is gone
And gone almost as soon as we began it.
So goes it nowadays!

THE OLD MOTHER,

It was not so—
Days did not hurry through sweet hours to
joy
When I was young, when I was bride and
wife!

FIRST WOMAN

Another blessed eventide is come
To bring to happy women-folk at last
Their weary men, all hungry for their supper.

A CHILD

And some for me. I wants my suppie too!

ANOTHER WOMAN

Well, there's a plenty. We are neighbors all
And what one lacks the others can supply,
For all the world will share the harvest feast.

THE OLD MOTHER,

Yea, all the world is here, or will be soon,
Save my good mate and my five strapping
lads
Who were my world and rotted years ago.

THE WOMAN

There, mother, there—forget the old sad past,
For all the world is sweet with harvest scent,
And we are glad. Come, share with us our
joy.

THE OLD MOTHER,

Forget? Forget? Who tells me to forget?
A silly chit with everything to learn,
A ninny who has lived while life is peace
And therefore thinks that peace has always
been
As it is now. Say, girl, would you forget
That man of yours torn from between your
breasts
And sent to splice with sabres and with
shells?
Could you forget a baby's filthy death
By plague or famine or infesting flies—
A son's abasement or a daughter's rape—

These things could you forget? I never shall.
I would be of another race and kind,
A woman who remembers what has been,
Who knows that some day it may come again

THE FIRST WOMAN

Poor soul, there—I am sorry. I did not know.
We speak but foolishly to soothe a pain
Which we have never felt.

THE OLD MOTHER,

Ah, pray that you
May never, never know what I have known.

THE WOMAN

Ay, that I will. But come, and share our joy,
For there is none to-night to presage woe.

THE OLD MOTHER,

None save myself. My old bones feel the
cold—
I sense a sorry blackening of the sun
As night comes on, and any heap of fruit,
Yes, any wagon load of yellow grain
May hide from these old eyes their enemy.

THE WOMAN

(shrugging her shoulders)

Well, hide your grief, poor soul, if grieve you
must;
The men, who look for rest, will soon be
home.

THE OLD MOTHER,

But not to me are any comings home,
Although I keep The World Inn day by day....
Yet 'tis an ill thing and a sign of trouble
For to be weeping when the men come home

The men, who should find smiles at set of
sun,
Who should be fed and coddled to their rest,
These splendid children, when they come to
us.
I will make ready. I will dry my tears.

*(Exit The Old Mother into the World
Inn. Voices are heard without, coming
nearer.)*

A WOMAN

The men!

ANOTHER WOMAN

The men!

ANOTHER WOMAN

My husband—there he is!

A CHILD

Here is my daddie! Daddie, gimme a kiss!

*(The men enter in groups of twos and
threes with dinner pails and tools. They
find their families or greet their
sweethearts and most of the happy
couples go off down the road together at
the left. A few enter The World Inn.
There is the rattle of dishes, laughter
and good cheer. The sun sinks*

*perceptibly and it grows darker. Enter
Capital and Labor, quarreling.)*

CAPITAL

The pumpkins here are mine, good fellow,
mine!
I bought the seed, you know.

LABOR

I broke the earth—
I strove with wind and frost and burning
drought
To make them grow more golden day by day.

CAPITAL

Tut, tut, man. That is nought. I own the land.
You can but work it since I give consent.
Small credit that a man does what he must
If he would live.

LABOR

I gave my very life.

CAPITAL

(snapping his fingers)

What is your life but like a billion more?

*(Enter Flip, costumed as gentleman of
fashion)*

FLIP

Are there indeed a billion Labors? If so, they
will soon keep you busy, Capital, old top, as
busy as you would like to keep them. You
may grow thin—O consummation devoutly
to be wished! just a little bit off the front—if

these chaps keep on giving their lives to your pumpkins. But if there be a billion just alike

—

CAPITAL

In all the world there are but few like me!

FLIP

Amen. So be it. Too many yous in one street car would be the hell of a crowd, if you travelled in street cars. And too many yous would be poor company for one another. Wherever one man has a bulge to his stomach, another must find his a siege and a retreat. Well, friends, tell me your troubles, and I will be a judge without the recall and a jury without opinions to settle the case.

LABOR

Both of us love the lady men call Trade.

FLIP

The prettiest of all she-devils, she—

LABOR

And she is pliant ever to his will
Who has most power. And we do both contend
That power resides in pumpkins—but I claim

—

CAPITAL

Of pumpkins we were speaking. Be exact.

(To Flip)

He claims them all because he planted them.
Could he have planted them without my aid

Who pay the wage that buys his daily bread?

LABOR

I furnish you, your bread, O Capital,
And cake besides. You do not live on
pumpkins!
All, all is mine. Without me you would die.

FLIP

Peace, peace. Neither of you could live on
pumpkins, nor on power, nor would it suffice
for either to have complete possession of his
heart's desire, the harlot Trade. To live on
pumpkins—Lord, what a diet! Thick—
yellow—mushy—with never a hint of
stimulation for the uplift of the soul. We must
have souls, nowadays, for it is the thing.
They are nearly as common as tuberculosis,
and quite as tragic. But those who go
awhoring think not deeply of their souls lest
they repent. And I would not feed my soul on
pumpkin to outwit Capital and appease Labor
—no not I. Rather would I turn viticulturist
and try the grape cure!

LABOR

Raisins or pumpkins, it is all the same;
These things are mine, for I have made them
be.
I, I deliver earth of what she bears
And am chief nurse at Nature's lying-in.

FLIP

A very shocking nurse I will be bound—to
go from the sacredness of Nature's childbed,
to woo Trade—verily, if the wages of sin be
death, that would be going from the cradle to
the grave!

CAPITAL

(self-righteously)

For my part I make no pretense at all!

FLIP

(slapping Labor on the shoulder)

Come, Labor, not so seriously, old top. It is not in good form to care so much. We are grown light of touch, to-day, and laugh at bombast. And as for the two of you, a true philosopher would tell you that, if you were a little more glib and smug, and Capital a little more smug and glib, men could scarce estimate the value of the one over the other? And what matters a label if, by accident, or skill, or the lack of it, the one of you can change places, sometimes, with the other? And what matters the ownership if I can so hamper your operations as to take too much toll from both?

CAPITAL

(sulky and bewildered)

I do but set my label on my own—

LABOR

A dollar sign on earth and sea and sky!

FLIP

A dollar sign is a good thing anywhere. I'd wear it over all the sense I have. And, were I to fill your place, Capital, I should be content with dollar signs and labels, and not dispute

with poor Labor about his pumpkin pie. I would even give him more than one slice if he wanted it. He would then think himself rich, and lapse into content for an aeon or two. And surely there is more than one way of winning a lady?

LABOR

Be silent, Flip; I do not like your wit.
This is The World Field that I till and sow
And woo and threaten, and at last, coerce,
Until it is the wife of my command
To bear me children of my days of toil.
Shall I be cheated of these children, then,
With smiling face and showy courtesy?
I tell you no. For I am grown too strong—
And I am wiser than I used to be—
I could make garbage of his flabby paunch
And beat his brains to swill!

FLIP

(with mock alarm, running to left and calling)

Trade! Trade! you jade—Come here and see
your precious lovers fight....

*(Enter Trade, disdainfully, glancing first
at Capital and then at Labor)*

CAPITAL

I claimed the pumpkins all for you, my dear.

LABOR

(with less gallantry)

What is not his no decent man can claim.

TRADE

(laughing immoderately)

Pumpkins? Who cares for pumpkins? No—
not I.

I only mentioned them to keep you busy,
For I can hardly settle with you yet,
Nor judge the better lover of the twain.
For, at this time, great kings take thought for
me—

Princes and leaders of the people crave
My kindness—and myself. You two must
wait.

LABOR

Know then it was not all for you I spoke,
But for a principle—for that I fight.

*(Labor turns up his sleeves, clenches his
fist and takes a stride or two toward
Capital, who is frightened and blows a
whistle in alarm. Enter Religion from
The World Inn, a little man in black,
carrying a book, who trots up to Capital
as to a master. Capital pinions his two
arms and holds Religion in front of him.
Labor laughs roughly and begins to pull
off his shirt.)*

LABOR

Come, Flip, your wit is all too deep for me,
But, if Religion is to second him,
I would depend on you in my good cause.
Come, help me strip and then, a fight, a fight!

FLIP

*(Hesitates, goes to help him, speaks
gently.)*

A fight is a noisy affair, Labor, and wakes many sleepers. There is one over in the corner who should not on any account be disturbed. For, once wakened, he is hard to quiet.

LABOR

You speak too late—come—help—my shirt is tight!

FLIP

*(seizing the shirt, gives one tug and then
withdraws in haste, holding his nose.)*

You are too sweaty, Labor. Sorry, old top, but I can't stand it. Muscles are a rare thing nowadays, and I would like to see yours, since you are not afraid to waken that old fear under the vines. And these modern epics are amusing, wherein Achilles carries a dinner pail and Ulysses turns syndicalist. But, if I must act as a second and pull off men's shirts, commend me to a man who has money enough to buy soap and time for a bath, and that, though he were not half so good to look upon.

LABOR

(outraged, and flinging his shirt at Flip)

Take you my sweat upon your silly face
And stand aside to watch me fight alone....

CAPITAL

*(Retreating and holding Religion in
front of himself)*

Preach me a gospel to this fighting fool,
A pretty gospel of The Prince of Peace,
Religion, you whom I have paid and kept.

RELIGION

*(Trying to command himself and
speaking hurriedly)*

I will, I will—but wait. For I must think—
The Word has not the weight that once it had.
Come, Labor, my good man, what is amiss?
Come, come, no fighting—that is very
wrong....
Be meek and humble as the good book says!

LABOR

I loved the good book and its precepts well
In the old days when first my faith in you
Kept me from fighting save at your behest
And for your sake. I listened to you, then.
You were the Light and in your way I
walked,
Loving and dreaming; but the dreams are
gone
Like your old stature, fervency and power.
Sermons in livery I will not heed,
A flunkey's stale rebuke I do abhor!
A bought man cannot teach the strong and
free—
My soul is pure, and will not brook your
touch!

FLIP

His soul? Where is it, I wonder? They always talk about them, but where are they? Two dunderheads and an adlepate trying to make righteousness out of their own inclinations by converse about souls! bah!

SOUL OF MAN

Yet, where men are, I am—yes, even here!

(All look about and show that their attention has been arrested, but no one sees Soul of Man, nor discovers where the voice comes from.)

LABOR

(to Religion)

Strip off that livery and get you gone.
Because of faith that once I felt in you
I cannot strike you now. But, O beware!
For *he* must meet me face to face alone.

RELIGION

(Struggling to free himself from Capital and escape)

If they would only listen to me, now—

FLIP

But they will not, Blackcoat, no. I can make men behave a few minutes at a time because I amuse them. One would think your derivative graces almost funny enough to serve the same purpose. But men do not want *you* to be funny. They would have you large and majestic, and to-day you do not seem big enough to enforce attention from any but an

audience of corpses. These two, Labor and Capital, are not corpses, but red-blooded men, having given themselves over to the same ha——fair lady, Trade. Unless you can regain your lost stature your day is over, Blackcoat, over. But do your best, for we still need you.

RELIGION

Then will I call my bastard brother Cult,
To help me out and to abate this strife—
O Cult, come hither, I have need of you.

*(Enter Cult in fantastic costume,
carrying a crystal into which he gazes.
He walks slowly, with an air of craft and
mystery, and speaks in a droning
monotone.)*

CULT

Abracadabra—someone spoke my name—
The aura that I wear about me shivered
As if for vocal contact. I am here.

*(While Cult is speaking Trade comes
slyly forward from the back, where she
has been sitting, watching in disdainful
amusement, and gradually draws nearer
to the sleeping Mars.)*

RELIGION

(to Cult)

Brother, I need you here to stop a fight;
Labor and Capital—

CULT

Hush—I know all.
I sense a mystery hidden in the brush—
I feel, feel, feel, who am so sensitive.
I will look through my crystal till I find it,
And when I find it, that will stop the fight!

FLIP

Abracadabra! He would look through a
crystal to find what is hidden in brush and
pumpkins.

*(Trade seats herself on the shield of
Mars and lights a cigarette)*

LABOR

Enough of nonsense. I am not a child
That I should swallow all this mystic mush.
If old Religion were what once he seemed,
He never would have called on you, O Cult.

*(Labor takes a step toward Capital
again, and Religion makes a gesture of
appeal to Flip.)*

FLIP

Blackcoat, there is no use. There is but one
enemy who can drain them of their feverish
passions and so reconcile them, the same
who lies sleeping under the brush in the
corner. He has slept long, and while he has
been sleeping, women have indulged their
husbands and borne too many children, and
the world is full to overflowing; men have
indulged their families in new luxuries of all
kinds. All fear temperance as they fear death,
for, like death it curbs desire. The Soul of
Man, of whom we constantly hear, has not

yet made himself conspicuous, although the
women's clubs claim to know all about him.
But, if the enemy should awaken—

(Mars stirs in his sleep)

CULT

*(Looking in another direction through
his crystal)*

I see it in my glass that he is dead—

*(Trade, leaning over Mars, and glancing
back at the others maliciously, drops her
cigarette on Mars and awakens him.
Mars sits up and looks about.)*

CULT

*(without seeing Mars and going off at
right)*

By all the initiates, my aura feels
The pressure of the knowledge of his death
Who was the olden enemy. I know all....

*(Mars rises and shakes his spear. Exeunt
all the others, Capital and Labor in
alarm, Religion timidly, Flip with a
philosopher's shrug, Trade laughing
contemptuously.)*

*(The sky grows dark and Mars strides
up and down, singing or chanting and
shaking his spear.)*

MARS

Long have I slept, but now have I awakened,
I, mighty Mars, the lover of the arrow,
I, mighty Mars, the giver of the sabre,
I, mighty Mars, the maker of the shrapnel,
Monarch of heroes, gallantry and death.

I am a spirit of man's body gendered,
And, in the race, I am for everlasting,
Calling mankind from home and task and
kindred,
Making men mad with foaming blood-
delight.
Kings I have kissed, with Victory and solace;
Kings I have ruined. Who can stand beside
me?
Who is strong to quell me? Let him show his
face?

Long have I slept, while Trade, the busy
harlot,
Kept her delights for Capital and Labor;
Now let the whirr of singing mills be silent!
Now let the factory whistles hush their
voices!
Now let the harvests in the fields be rotted!
Now let the shops be shut, the churches
empty,
That I may fill them with my sick and dying
—
Mine is dominion over day and night.

Night is at hand, and, in The World Inn
feasting
Sitteth mankind, while I am keeping vigil.
Such blood is rich—the sweeter for my
drinking—
Yea, I am avid of the fat of babies—

None will I have but such as are the strongest

—

Cleanest and truest, proudest, richest, bravest

—

(Never a weakling can abide my presence
For I am Mars, and speak the word of death)
Lo! I will call my servants to my colors—
One deed of fury licks a world to ashes—
Bright, blasting winds sweep over croft and
hearthside
Leaving life dead. Who comes to challenge
me?

SOUL OF MAN

I challenge you, O Mars, though straitly
bound.

Lo! I shall break with love your ugly power.

MARS

A slave who would defy his conqueror!
Why, I did bind you with resistless chains
Long centuries ago when earth was young.

SOUL OF MAN

I have grown strong since then.

MARS

Not strong enough.
For I have wakened from my years of rest
As zealous as a child to play his game,
And you, not I, shall feel the limits of time
Grow thin and sag and break beneath your
form,
Letting you fall into annihilation
Through crackling fringes of what might
have been.

SOUL OF MAN

You rave, O Mars. What ravel with my
weight
Would break with yours, and yet this ancient
stuff,
This fibre of the human race is strong.
You have most straitly bound, who cannot
slay,
That I might work the less in your long sleep,
You, drunk with blood of lovers, satiate
With rape of many women! Yet men grow
And love you less than when your sleep
began....

*(He struggles to free himself from his
bonds, fails, in the attempt, falls forward
on his face, groans. Mars laughs.)*

MARS

Now I have need of my good servant,
Science.
Ho! Science!

*(Enter Science in the costume of the
laboratory with a test tube in his hand.)*

SCIENCE

Yes, mighty Mars, I am here.

MARS

Science, once more I have great need of you.
I want the howitzers of Titan gods,
And mad torpedoes mightier than of old,
And airy fleets to rend the dizzy Heavens,
Zeppelins and lighter craft, ill-omened birds
To prey upon the towns that lie below;
And I want wicked, wondrous submarines,
Sly, devilish monsters of the deeps unknown,

And battle cruisers ruinous and grim.
Make me a ration that will keep men strong
The longer for their task of blood and tears,
Which is my game, my spectacle, my joy.
And find me doctors, apt with splintered
bones,
And keen to cut the rotten flesh from sound,
And to sew bodies up like burlap sacks
That they may keep their contents still
secure.
What say you, Science, will you serve me
still?

SCIENCE

You know I am a neutral servant, Mars,
To whomsoever can command my laws.
I have not much emotion for a choice.
Yet, were I free, to-day, I would say no;
For I have great discoveries at heart
And great experiments have undertaken
Which yet may bring milleniums to men,
Which must be interrupted if I yield.
Therefore I would return to my own task,
And yet, if Capital and Labor will it,
I must obey you. I must do your will.

MARS

Labor and Capital!

(Enter Labor and Capital, still sullen)

I must have war;
Capital you must fight to save your own
In every separate nation where you dwell.
You, Labor, in all lands that you call home,
Must fight to guard it, and acquit you well.

LABOR

I like it not at all!

CAPITAL

No more do I!

LABOR

I wanted Trade, and peace.

CAPITAL

And I the same.

LABOR

And we had questions of our own to settle,
This Capital and I. Not yet, old Mars!

MARS

Ay, now. Why Capital, you have grown so
great
You can work wonders over all the world.
Have you no pride, O Labor? Such a hero,
With such great shoulders and such stalwart
thighs,
With such swart manhood and such virile
temper,
Meseems should hear my mandate with more
joy.
For both of you can learn the way of fighting
And better settle your own private quarrel
For lessons stern that I alone can teach you.

*(Labor and Capital turn toward each
other and take a step or two away from
Mars. They are muttering and
murmuring together as Flip enters.)*

FLIP

May Heaven have mercy on the sheepskin
degree I cribbed for in college! What say the
sages? A common fear unites foes of long
standing. And here, verily, are Labor and
Capital discoursing earnestly together like
young brides on the subject of biscuits. Are
you, then, the cause of their peace, O Mars?

MARS

Well asked. Indeed they are too much afraid
To seem like men. Men used to be more bold
When I was young. When earth was young
with me
They were not cowards—

LABOR AND CAPITAL

(wheeling about angrily)

Nor are we cowards today!

FLIP

More than a coward would fear you, master
of blood-suckers. I like you not myself. I
have come to distract you a moment from
your fell intention. If I were forced to do
military service I should hope to eschew your
company, albeit you have taken your place in
history as a celebrity, some lion, take it from
me. But, roar as you will, I won't invite you
to my dinner parties. Nor could you convert
me to your cause, for I am always ready to
see both sides of a question, to embrace both
ladies at once, as it were, with equal ardor
and love. Apropos of that, friend Mars, a flea
in your ear!...

MARS

Talk if you must, but do not talk too long....

FLIP

(speaking rapidly—even earnestly)

If you raise hob now, it will not add to your popularity one whit. There is nothing but stage bombast to fight about. There is a little need of Capital for expansion, and of Labor for more bread, since he breeds fifty per cent. too fast. There is the hope of enlarging certain rooms in The World Inn to accommodate more strangers, or else of reducing the number of travellers who wish to sojourn therein. But you are not essential in the development of these designs, nor will they give you a good background for the acting of melodrama. You cannot shout “God and the right!” as you did in the days when you were popular and more or less necessary. To-day you are a bluff and we know it. So does your enemy, one Soul of Man, a personage as yet invisible to me, who may one day dissolve even my divine impudence into prudent beauty and make a hymnal out of my wit. With this thought I leave you. Look well before you leap, you heavy-weight. You may land in the trenches!

(Exit Flip)

MARS

He talks too much. I live for gallant deeds!
You fellows here were arguing with me
About my war. I will have your consent—
They would be cowards who would answer
nay....

(Reenter Flip)

FLIP

Here is The Daily Bewilderer running
headlines that will delight you, O Mars.
Somebody has shot an arch-duke somewhere.
Now, indeed, we shall be unable to hold you
back! Now indeed we have fine cause for
war!

LABOR AND CAPITAL

(going rapidly to Mars)

We are not cowards. We serve you, mighty
Mars.

MARS

My shield, my spear! Now am I well content.
Go, Science, and prepare for this great war
As Capital and Labor shall agree,
And send me Poetry, my ancient friend!

*(Exeunt Science, Labor, Capital, and
Flip. Enter Poetry.)*

MARS

Poetry, it was you, who made my fame,
Who taught the people all the best of me—

POETRY

Mars, I shall sing your praises nevermore,
Nor shall the people need you evermore.
I sing the people, as I always have,
And, as they change, the new song of new
times.
Who till The World Field for the harvest's
sake

And feast in The World Inn at set of sun,
And mate with healthy joy in one another,
And gladly breed the children of the flesh
And of the spirit, and who build our homes,
Who cleanse and fashion, and repair your
wrongs,
These are my folk, and their new songs I
sing,
And a new era, burning bright with peace.

*(A chain breaks and frees the right arm
of Soul of Man, who extends it in
blessing toward Poetry.)*

SOUL OF MAN

O Poetry, your word has broken bonds
Forged long ago when earth was very young.
Sing you for me till you and I together
Shall leaven all this lump of humankind
With the new yeast of kindly brotherhood.
We'll purge the old earth of this festering fear
And heal this cancer! Poetry, sing on!

MARS

(scornfully, to Poetry)

I need you not, then. I can do without you
If I have Music and her seducer, Glamour.
Come, Music!

*(Exit Poetry. Enter Music, in bonds to
Glamour.)*

GLAMOUR

I brought her in. She would have stayed
behind
To sing with Poetry for all mankind.

But, once deceived, she can go free no more
Save in the triumph of the Soul of Man,
Who is your thrall. Come, Music, my good
wench,
Tell Mars your service and your song are his.

MUSIC

If I must give myself against my will
And where my instinct would make swift
refusal,
I will so give myself through Mars to men
That, treading in his flashing path of pain,
They shall know less of him because of me.
And I shall be their glory when his guns
Vomit black horror upon body and soul,
And I shall be their solace in the hours
When stiffening Death would have them for
his own.
Oh woe is me that listened unto Glamour!
Yet I await your freedom, Soul of Man.

MARS

Tush, girl, a beauty like your precious self
Has ever need of a more lusty lover—
And such am I, and such is Glamour here!
What captive can a woman's kisses keep?
Come, take my kiss, and then, throughout the
world,
Sing me the ballads that do make men wild!
Give me the froward chanteys of the camp,
Beat me the marches unto Victory,
Or, with bravado, even unto Death.
Come, come; begin. The whole world waits
for you!

*(Music wipes tears from her eyes and
sets a bugle to her lips. Exit Music,*

*sounding the advance, followed by
Glamour. Then in close succession and
increasing volume are heard the
national anthems of the warring nations
of Europe, in the order in which they
declared war. It is dark and lights flash
out in the distance. There is more or less
noise and confusion at the back. Horses,
artillery, men, crossing and recrossing,
running, marching, working. Mars,
proudly erect in the center shouts
“Good!” and repeats it. A man,
marching in with others, leaves his
group and runs to the steps of The World
Inn.)*

THE MAN

Are you there, dear? I have come to say
farewell!

A WOMAN

(coming out to meet him.)

Beloved, must you go? I am alone,
Alone in all the world, and of our love
A child, a little human flower is coming—
Surely I need you most!

THE MAN

Tell him his father tried to do his duty
And loved his country. Dear one, I must go....

*(They kiss passionately and the man
rejoins his group and marches off. The
woman flings herself down on the steps
of The World Inn and weeps bitterly.
There is more noise and confusion and*

*then three youths come to the steps and
call out.)*

THREE YOUTHS

Mother.... O Mother.... Mother!

*(A woman comes forward holding wide
arms for the three)*

THE WOMAN

Children, you are not going—you, my
babies?

It seems but yesterday my body held you—
It seems but yesterday your toys were lying,
Toy cannon and bright soldiers made of tin
Upon the cottage floor. O children, children,
Who are just old enough at last to leave me—
Surely you will not leave your poor old
mother?

ONE BOY

The bugle called us and we must be going—

THE WOMAN,

A bugle calls more strongly than a mother....

THE SECOND BOY

We will come back to you as heroes,
mother....

THE WOMAN,

You were my heroes when you were my
babies....

THE THIRD BOY

You would not have us cowards to be near
you....

THE WOMAN,

I am Love's coward—I never ... should ...
have ... made you....

(The lads kiss their mother and tear themselves from her arms. The anthems of the nations are repeated. The guns volley in the distance, getting louder and louder. Fires flame up and there is more or less noise and confusion. A woman runs out from The World Inn, sobbing.)

THE WOMAN,

I want my lover who was never mine.
Will they not let him come to say farewell?
Where are you, O Desired of all my days?

(She runs hither and thither looking for him, wildly, and finally stumbles against Mars, shrieks, and tries to escape, but is caught and held by him. Mars roars his elation and carries her off at left screaming. There is a pause, utter quiet, absolute darkness. Then Mars returns alone and stumbles into The World Inn.)

MARS

Now I can feast me to my full content,
And then, a little while, I shall have rest.

(Exit Mars. There is another pause and silence while it gradually becomes lighter. Men and women are heard groaning, and, in the pale, eerie light, weird moth-like figures, like ghosts of

the dead, flit here and there across the field. When it becomes light enough to see, all the world is changed. Flowers, fruit, produce are gone. The wagon that held the grain is now filled with corpses.

On the ground are the sick and wounded, bandaged. The women waiting on them are lean, ragged, haggard. A few children are huddled together in silent terror. The scene is blackened as if by fire. On the steps of The World Inn sits The Old Mother, as in the beginning.)

A WOMAN

The dawn is nearly here, the strange grey dawn!

ANOTHER WOMAN

What bodes it now? Sunset or dawn or noon
Are all alike to those who have seen hell
And bear in body and soul the brand of sorrow.

THE OLD MOTHER,

'Twas even as I feared and as I spoke.
So was it, children, in my younger days,
The days that I can nevermore forget.

(She rises and hobbles toward the wounded men.)

Children of mothers' flesh this cannot last
Forever. I am old and soon I die,
And nothing can torment me very long,
Wherefore I speak what youth might fear to say

To you, as to my sons of long ago,
Who died, as all your friends have died, in
war.

A MAN

Speak, for we listen.

THE OLD MOTHER,

That is very well,
For this is murder that ye did commit,
For glamour and for vanity and lust,
For selfishness in trade, and for all freedom
To breed your own kind over all the earth,
Each for himself and his own kind alone,
Forgetting that ye all have suckled mothers,
Forgetting that ye owe us fealty,
And that ye owe it to yourselves to be
Staunch farmers of the World Field, and good
friends,
One flesh, one love, one state, one family.

A MAN

Even that we might be able to achieve
If one would help us to the holy way.
We fight not for ourselves, good mother, no!
We fight for place, for honor and for home,
For what the great, who lead us, say is best,
The whims of senators, the dreams of kings;
And often know not why our blood is poured,
A turbulent, unholy river of lust.
And when the people cry for war and shout
The sure destruction of another nation
It is because they fear and know that fear
Is far more terrible than roughest strife.
Nor are we fools to give up life with joy,
Save when the feud of Capital and Labor
Has made our minds a Hell of sordid warfare

And clothed our gayety in querulous crepe.
Then, in our desperate mourning for young
joy,
The sweetness and variety of life,
The rainbow radiance and the cloth of gold
That are youth's great inalienable right,
We know no other way and follow blindly
The one mad way that gives a thrill of glory,
And frees our pulsing life. So are we made....
But we, who lie on beds of bloody sweat,
Washed by our women's tears, we fain would
see
Another era of mankind made new,
Young Titans, strong enough to war on war,
This hoary curse from the stringy throat of
Mars
To answer and to silence and to choke!

OTHER MEN

Mother, the way—the upward way from
Hell!

THE OLD MOTHER,

I'll show it, thankfully, and, if I do,
I can go gaily, gladly to my grave
As one who treads a quickstep of her youth.
See, children, that strange figure, Soul of
Man,
In bonds to our arch enemy and his?
He is our friend, and all our life would share
If we would only take him for our own.
There is no morning made by sun and sea
And towering mountains, larksong, flower
breath
And rapture, but his coming into it
Can give a finer and diviner joy.
There is no darkness, damp and fraught with

death,
Down-bearing, stifling, but his coming
makes
A rift of light, an easement of the strain.
Now Mars, his foe, is held in ugly sleep,
Full-fed on thin, raw flesh of women's babes,
Deep drunken on the sap of many hearts—
Be not deceived, for he will wake again,
Unless ye learn of this good Soul of Man
How to defy this Mars, and get you peace.
Children, commend you to the Soul of Man.

A MAN

How can we free you, free you, Soul of Man?

SOUL OF MAN

I tremble—for my hour of joy is near....
Ah, can it be that I shall rise at last,
Gay winged and glorious with the rising sun,
To hover where mankind shall bloom anew
In The World Field where only stubble was?
Hearken! For now, together ye must go,
Not here a few and there a few, but all,
And hale him forth, this monster butcher,
now,
While he is full and has no lust to feed,
Yes, hale him forth into the light and look,
And looking, know him truly as he is.
If for that look he wake, defy his power,
For your own sakes fight one more fight for
peace.

A MAN

Alas, we are too weak for this god Mars,
And some of us have known him all too well.

SOUL OF MAN

Who does my bidding has no sense of fear—
For all the stars will shine into his night
And all the winds acclaim him to the end.
And this was true of Socrates and Christ,
Of Lincoln and of all great harvesters
In The World Field. It shall be so for you
On the same terms of brave obedience.
Do ye my bidding and ye shall be free
And I, to live and grow with you, forever.

*(The people talk together in twos and
threes. Enter Capital and Labor, two
lean cripples supporting one another,
followed by Flip, who is wearing deep
mourning.)*

SOUL OF MAN

Labor and Capital, be well content
To lend me but yourselves. I ask no money.
I lay no tax upon you as did Mars.
And I do promise you an opulent peace,
Wrought out with right goodwill between
you soon
For I know well what others do not know,
But should discover by your present plight,
That you must ever win or lose together,
Sharing each other's burden and reward
And I do promise sweet regeneration
Your broken selves shall be made whole
again
When you have helped the people set me
free....

(Capital and Labor discuss the offer.)

FLIP

What will you do for me, O Soul of Man,
whom I can see and perceive at last? I have
lost many rich relations in this war and
profited nothing—wherefore I wear
mourning! But if I turn my wit to good
account by making men's anger funny, what
will you do for me?

SOUL OF MAN

Your name, I'll change, and you yourself,
good Flip,
You shall be my own Humor, kindly spoken,
And my strong Reason leading men to Truth
—

But look who comes with face of Galahad
And thews of Ajax, wearing spotless white—

*(Enter Religion, a new personality,
athletic and beautiful, wearing a short
white garment with the symbols of the
great religions wrought in gold upon the
hem and carrying a shining cross. All
the people turn and look and with one
accord make obeisance.)*

THE PEOPLE

Religion.... O Religion.... Religion!

SOUL OF MAN

Religion, have you come to serve the people?

LABOR

(joyfully)

Are you the old guest, radiant and serene?

CAPITAL

And will you lead against this bully, Mars?

RELIGION

Listen, for with new power I come to you
Seeking to serve, claiming a mighty task.
I was a sinner who had nibbled Truth
And let its sweetness all dissolve away
Into the rancid spittle of dead dogmas.
The loss of your allegiance was the stroke
That cleansed and chastened me. I have
spewed out
All the old wordy liquor of dead days,
And all the prowess of my being now
Shall foster and defend the Soul of Man.

*(The people cheer. A chain breaks,
releasing the left arm of Soul of Man
who reaches out both arms in
benediction.)*

SOUL OF MAN

Then welcome, and thrice welcome, good
Religion—
Coming to serve, men will be glad to follow.
O happy folk of ages yet to be
New flowering from the pollen of the past,
I see your budding glory everywhere.
This is the spring and this the shining dawn
—

The men shall be as great grave trees at rest
With the new strength that grapples, grows,
and gives,
And the world's women even as her men,
And fruitful as the orchards of the valley,
And little children dancing with delight
Shall blossom fearlessly, in perfect grace,
Like windblown poppies nodding in the sun.

And all The World Field shall be cropped in
peace
And all the sheaves of life shall be brought
home—
Such fruitage for High God is in your lives
As I had never dreamed in life's beginning.
This is the dawn, the spring, and we are
planting
The harvest that the race shall gather in.
Therefore to Mars, and quickly bring him
hither!

*(Religion and The Old Mother lead the
people up the steps and into The World
Inn, the people cheering and shouting.
Then there is a moment of silence, after
which they come out again, carrying the
dead body of Mars.)*

A MAN

He is dead, old Mars, and must have died of
fear!

*(The chains drop from the body of Soul
of Man, and he, leaping to his feet, runs
to take his place in the center, in front of
the body of Mars and in a widening
semi-circle of the people. His black
garment falls on Mars, and Soul of Man
is transfigured, a radiant figure in blue
and gold and crimson, with flaming
wings rising behind him and above. The
people, also, are glorified by the rising
of the sun behind them. They kneel.)*

*(There is heard the triumphant singing
of "The Hallelujah Chorus").*

CURTAIN

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